

Duty for Duty's Sake: Kant and the Categorical Imperative

An original lesson plan inspired by **Robert Johnson & Adam Cureton's** the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* entry on *Kant's Moral Philosophy*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* or *Robert Johnson & Adam Cureton*. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/kant-moral/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

65 minutes

TOPICS

Ethics

“Can an action be truly moral if you only do it because you're inclined to, or does genuine morality require acting from duty alone, regardless of your feelings?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Kant's distinction between acting 'in accordance with duty' and acting 'from duty,' and why only the latter has moral worth for Kant.
- Formulate the Categorical Imperative in both its Universal Law and Humanity formulations and distinguish it from hypothetical imperatives.
- Apply the Universal Law and Humanity formulations to a moral dilemma and evaluate whether they yield the same verdict.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Printed handout with Kant's two formulations of the Categorical Imperative in plain-language paraphrase
- Case-study cards: a false-promise scenario and the 'murderer at the door' scenario
- Two-column note-taking sheet: hypothetical vs. categorical imperatives

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Shopkeeper

8 min

Present Kant's own example: one shopkeeper doesn't overcharge a confused customer only because dishonesty would be bad for business, while a second shopkeeper doesn't overcharge because it would be wrong. Ask students which shopkeeper's behavior is 'more moral' and why, even though both act the same way toward the customer.

Direct Instruction: Duty, Good Will, and the Categorical Imperative

20 min

Explain Kant's claim that a good will is the only thing good without qualification, and that only acting from duty (out of respect for the moral law) rather than merely in accordance with duty (from inclination or self-interest) has moral worth. Contrast hypothetical imperatives (commands conditional on a desire, 'if you want X, do Y') with the Categorical Imperative, which commands unconditionally. Present both the Universal Law formulation (act only on maxims you could will to become universal laws) and the Humanity formulation (treat humanity, in yourself and others, always as an end and never merely as a means).

Small-Group Application: The False Promise

15 min

In small groups, students apply the Universal Law formulation to the case of someone making a false promise to get a loan they don't intend to repay. Groups test whether the maxim 'I will make false promises when convenient' could be universalized without contradiction, and record their reasoning about why or why not.

Whole-Class Debate: The Murderer at the Door

16 min

Introduce Kant's own notorious hard case: a murderer asks you where your friend, who is hiding in your house, has gone. Kant famously argued you may not lie even here. Split the class into those defending Kant's answer and those defending a modified Kantian position that permits refusal to answer or even deception in extreme cases, and run a structured debate.

Closure

6 min

Ask students to summarize, in one sentence each, what they find most compelling and most troubling about grounding morality entirely in reason and universalizable duty rather than in outcomes or feelings.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is Kant right that an action has no moral worth if it's done merely from inclination, even if it's the same act with the same effect on everyone involved?
- 2 Does the false-promising maxim really generate a logical contradiction when universalized, or only a practical inconvenience?
- 3 Was Kant's own answer to the murderer-at-the-door case — that lying is always wrong — too rigid, and if so, does that damage the Categorical Imperative itself or just Kant's application of it?
- 4 How is the Humanity formulation different from the Universal Law formulation? Can you imagine an act that would pass one test but fail the other?
- 5 Does grounding morality in reason, rather than happiness, God, or social convention, make Kant's ethics more or less persuasive to you?

Assessment

Students select one of two additional maxims not discussed in class (e.g., 'I will cheat on this exam if it will help me and no one will ever find out' or 'I will break this appointment because keeping it is inconvenient') and apply both



the Universal Law and Humanity formulations of the Categorical Imperative in a short written analysis, explaining whether the two formulations agree and defending which formulation they find more persuasive.

Extension Activity

Have students research one real ethical controversy (e.g., whistleblowing or paternalistic public health laws) and write a short analysis of how a strict Kantian, reasoning only from the Categorical Imperative, would likely judge it — and whether they think Kant's answer is too rigid for the real-world complexity of the case.

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